

In campaign mode

A young man's last minute frenzied handshakes and hectic embraces are enough to show the old guard that politics can be a profession too

■ By Chitra Subramanyam

The car screeches to a halt outside the college and he jumps out. The marigold garland around his neck, the clustering media and the way he stops to meet every student, are a dead giveaway. Meet Abhishek Tandon, 21, the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad's presidential candidate for the Delhi

STUDENT POLITICS

DELHI



place, slipping into the role of an aspiring politician with ease. After all, this is familiar ground. Both his uncles stood for the DUSU elections. His father Bhupendra, a businessman, is also supportive, helping with the campaigning.

A day later, Tandon's still upbeat. The results are in, but he has lost. Not by much, just around 4,000 votes. "We will be a

ISHAN TANKHA



CAMPAIGN TRAIL: Tandon at Kirori Mal College

University Students Union (DUSU) elections. He stops to give interviews, answers incessant questions, envelops his friends in bear hugs and then stoops down to touch a police officer's feet. The weather has been oppressive for days now, but Tandon isn't bothered. It's election day and he has had only three days to campaign. The earlier candidate bowed out of the elections after the Lyngdoh Committee recommendations, which only allow those with a no-failure record. Tandon took his

shadow DUSU," he says. The politician mode is visible. Only the Nehru cap is missing. "Student elections are all about money, glamour, muscle and beautiful girls who are seen for the 10 days of campaigning and then not seen for 10 years," he says.

But this can change, he says, ever an optimist. And while students prefer to avoid politics, Tandon belongs to that category of the youth who are determined to make politics their profession. Especially if it comes with the blessing of the family firm.

25,000
STUDENTS VOTED IN
THIS YEAR'S DUSU
POLLS